





Photographs by BHAVESH BHATI

LEARNINGS FROM THE CAFE HAVE BEEN DISTILLED IN THE NEW MENU, WITH COCKTAILS DEVOTED TO INDIAN CITIES AND THE RUSTIC INTERIORS MADE MODERN

Farzi Café launched at this very spot in 2014. "There were only three modern Indian restaurants in the world then: Indian Accent in Delhi, Gaggan in Bangkok, and Masala Library—which is owned by us—in Mumbai, but nothing in a casual format," says Kalra, who wanted to create the same sense of wonder in an accessible setting. Farzi, with its quirky offerings, was a runaway hit, and has subsequently grown to around 20 outlets currently, including overseas in New York, Seattle and London. These will all gradually morph into Farzi. Forward.



The learnings of the past decade have been distilled into the new menu, where 80 per cent of the dishes are completely fresh. While the cocktail menu celebrates the great culinary cities of India, the coffee menu is a playful take on the beverage. The refreshed interiors have moved away from the previous rustic aesthetic to embrace a more modern design language.

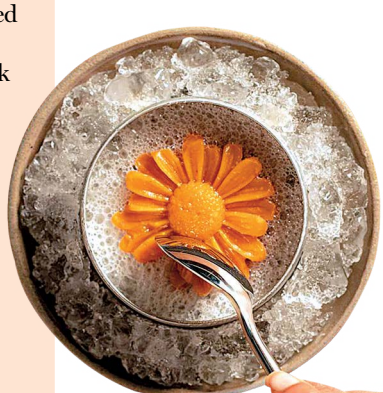
As for food trends, "regional Indian food is going to have a major resurgence again", feels Kalra. "You're also going to see a lot of matcha and coffee brands pop up. You're also going to see smaller omakase-style chef-driven restaurants."

While Kalra, 48, says running restaurants is not for everyone—"there are too many moving parts... it's a high failure rate business... it's time-consuming... don't get into it for glamour reasons"—he believes if one is genuinely passionate about food, it can be "the most rewarding business". ■

—Amit Dixit

▼ NILA, *Bengaluru*

A stunning, new chef-led space in Bengaluru's Cambridge layout, Chef Rahul Sharma's Nila ('moon' in Tamil) is an ode to lesser-known regional Indian flavours, with the menu set to change every three months. The inaugural menu, inspired by Nagaland, features smoked meats, foraged greens, bamboo and fermented ingredients. The 12-course meal features dishes like Black Soy Bean Tart, Yam Milk & Bamboo Broth, Pickled Persimmons Kebab and the Tree Tomato Custard (pic). The desserts—Naga Basil Cake and Sichuan Pepper Ice-Cream—are by Chef Garima Tharwani.





◀ SABORES, *Goa*

The legacy of the Hotel Mandovi, especially its much-loved Rio Rico restaurant, lives on in Sabores, a new 60-seater Goan restaurant at the members-only Clube de Palma in Bambolim, opened by Akshay Quenim, scion of the family which ran the legendary hotel until it shut in 2019.

▼ YOURS TRULY, *Kolkata*

Set in a beautifully restored Art Deco bungalow in Bhowanipore, all of which it occupies, including the lawns, Yours Truly Coffee Roaster has multiple offerings under the same roof. There's an on-site coffee roaster, which serves both retail and direct-to-business customers. There's a full-fledged bakery which produces fresh baked goods daily. And then there's a café with a sizeable continental menu which has something for everyone. Needless to say, they take their coffee very seriously.

—compiled by ***Amit Dixit***